

Breaking the glass ceiling: Afshan Fathima defied odds, reaching the final of IMMAF World Championships despite challenges and stereotypes.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

usually compete in boxing, judo and wrestling competitions. Within a few months of training, my coach entered my name in a district-level competition in boxing. Although I was nervous since I hadn't competed before, I ended up winning. Another few months later, I competed at my first national amateur championships in Lucknow, and once again I ended up winning," she says.

While the gold medal she won in Lucknow earned her some level of respect at home, Afshan knew it would always be hard for her parents to completely come to terms with her career. That was her key to becoming as independent as possible. "My parents have already gone far beyond their comfort zone to even accept that I can be an MMA fighter. Sometimes when they see me in shorts, they will grumble and say they gave me too much freedom. I like to live life on my own terms. I've never asked my parents for any money to fund my training or competition. My dad used to be in business, but he had to shut that down after he made a lot of losses. I also have two younger sisters, whom my parents are responsible for. At first, I used to beg my coach to charge me a nominal fee. I promised I'd pay him back when I started earning. After graduation, I worked in sales for Jaguar India, but I realised I wasn't getting the time to train like I wanted. I then started working as a coach in my MMA gym itself. MMA isn't a sport where, as an athlete, you get easily sponsored by the government or private organisations. So, if I have to compete in competitions, I have to raise my own funds," she says.

Afshan says she had to save up for a year in order to pay for her fight camp, nutrition, travel and competition fees for her first IMMAF World Championships this year.

It's not been an easy journey, and

